GROUNDED AI PRACTICE

The UK's AI Skills Ambition

Posture, delivery, and the gap between them

Independent research report. Preliminary findings from a project at its research and pilot-design stage. Evidence, inference and opinion are distinguished throughout, and every source is tagged by its likely interest. Interests are declared in §8.

Overview / Editorial

The UK Government intends to upskill 10 million workers in AI by 2030. That ambition rests on the AI Skills Hub, a national platform launched in June 2025 and opened to all UK adults in January 2026.

The programme funding it, BridgeAI, published its third annual report in March 2026. At the end of 2025 it recorded 1,700 skills course completions and 126 accreditations, against £74.6 million allocated from a £100 million budget. Both sets of numbers are published by the government. Neither appears next to the other.

That gap is not, by itself, a scandal. National programmes take time and three years is early. The more useful question is whether the institution running it is equipped to close the distance. On that, the government's own auditors have been unusually direct.

This report sets three things side by side: what has been promised, what has been delivered, and what Parliament and the National Audit Office say about the capability of the bodies delivering it. All three come from government-published material. The argument here does not depend on outside commentators, though several reached the same conclusions first.

One theme recurs throughout. The guidance is good. The frameworks exist, they are evidence-based, and they were commissioned by the same departments now failing to apply them. The problem is not that nobody knows what effective AI training looks like. It is that knowing has not translated into building.

1. The ambition, and where its numbers come from

The AI Opportunities Action Plan, published in January 2025, positions AI as a central driver of UK productivity and growth. Innovate UK's February 2026 white paper puts a figure on the prize: AI adoption could boost the UK economy by up to £400 billion by 2030.

That figure is worth following back, because it recurs across government communications, including a gov.uk announcement headlined around a “£400bn AI skills gap”. The white paper attributes it to Public First, a consultancy. Public First's work in this area was commissioned by Microsoft, which has separately committed £2.5 billion of UK investment over three years. The stated method classified more than 17,000 task-occupation combinations using GPT-4, applied to the United States O*NET occupational database, then mapped the results onto ONS data through a 20-year technology diffusion curve.

> NOTE
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> **On the £400 billion figure**
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> This is not an allegation of bad faith, and the estimate may well be reasonable. But a headline number underpinning national policy was produced by a consultancy for a technology vendor, using an AI model to classify American occupational data. It is not an ONS or OBR projection and should not be repeated as though it were.

The stated ambitions, as published:

Economic prize	Up to £400 billion added to the UK economy by 2030 (Public First, cited by Innovate UK and the AI Opportunities Action Plan).
Workforce target	10 million workers upskilled by 2030 — the stated ambition of the AI Skills Hub.
Programme budget	£100 million for BridgeAI, from UKRI's Technologies Mission Fund and Innovate UK, running since 2023.
The platform	The AI Skills Hub, described by Innovate UK as the UK's first-of-its-kind, government-funded, free at point-of-use AI skills platform.

2. What has actually been delivered

BridgeAI's year-three report, produced by Digital Catapult for Innovate UK, records the following position at the end of 2025.

£74.6m	Grant funding allocated, from the £100 million programme budget. Most of this supported funded AI projects rather than skills activity.
5,000+	Organisations supported across all programme activity.
~12,000	Individuals reached.
1,700+	AI skills courses completed.
126	Accreditations gained.

Source: Innovate UK BridgeAI, Year three in review, March 2026. These are programme-wide figures for BridgeAI as a whole, not for the AI Skills Hub specifically. They are self-reported by a consortium delivery partner writing for its funder, and no independent audit of them has been located.

The Hub's own numbers are not published

The AI Skills Hub is the government's flagship AI skills platform and carries the 10-million-worker ambition. Across the 81 pages of its parent programme's annual report it is named once, in a subordinate clause noting that training work "was supported through activity within the AI Skills Hub".

No Hub-specific usage, registration, completion or outcome figures appear anywhere in that report. Attempts to read the platform directly returned HTTP errors to unauthenticated requests across two separate research passes. As far as this research has established, the public currently cannot find out how many people have used the platform, or what happened to them afterwards.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE THIS

The absence of published usage data is the finding here — not a claim that the numbers must be bad. If the Hub's figures exist and are strong, publishing them would resolve the question immediately. A Freedom of Information request is the obvious next step, and this project intends to make one.

⚠ 3. Where the guidance contradicts the product

Innovate UK's February 2026 white paper gives employers a five-step approach to AI adoption. Its fifth step, on upskilling, tells them to "use diagnostics and workforce planning tools to map required capabilities" and to "design targeted, role-specific learning pathways", creating "differentiated learning journeys for leaders, operational teams, technical specialists, and frontline workers".

Three reviews of the Hub, published separately and not citing one another, report that the platform does none of these things.

> *"A mixture of existing training content loosely connected by the topic of AI."*
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> — LSE Impact of Social Sciences blog (Cardoso-Silva & Brown), on the AI Skills Hub

Source	Evidential role	Key finding
LSE Impact of Social Sciences blog Independent academic — LSE Data Science Institute / Digital Skills Lab	Independent policy analysis	Courses organised by technology vendor, not by the competencies the government's own research identifies as most needed.
Techosaurus / Quantum Rise Commercial AI-training providers — competing interest (flagged)	Observed platform behaviour	No organisational-readiness support, vendor lock-in, no practice sandbox, no diagnostics or scaffolding.

Source	Evidential role	Key finding
The Human Co. Commercial AI-training/consulting — competing interest (flagged)	Observed platform behaviour	Rated 3/10 on design despite adequate course content; intermediate learners shown ~71% beginner-level material; progress tracking “nearly invisible”.

Two of the three reviewers run businesses competing with the platform they reviewed, and are flagged accordingly. Their findings nonetheless align closely with the independent academic critique. That corroboration covers the broad structural problem, not every number: figures such as “71%” or “3/10” come from individual reviews, not replicated evaluation, and should be read as illustrative.

The contradiction is visible inside the white paper itself

The clearest evidence does not come from any reviewer. It comes from the white paper's own pages. Having recommended targeted, role-specific pathways, it presents three skills employers should build against a column headed “Relevant courses on the AI Skills Hub”. All three rows say the same thing.

Self-development	AI Skills Hub course catalogue
AI governance and compliance	AI Skills Hub course catalogue
Change management	AI Skills Hub course catalogue

Reproduced from Innovate UK, Unlocking UK Economic Growth through AI, February 2026.

Asked to name specific courses for specific skills, the government's own white paper points three times at an undifferentiated catalogue. That is the “directory, not a programme” critique, demonstrated on the government's own record.

This is not a case of missing evidence. The same research programme produced PRIMES, a detailed framework for effective AI training, in June 2026. The Alan Turing Institute, with DSIT and Innovate UK BridgeAI, launched an AI Skills for Business Competency Framework in May 2024. A competency framework and a training-design framework both exist, both government-commissioned. Neither appears to have shaped the platform.

⚖️ 4. A capability problem, not only a delivery problem

In March 2025 the Public Accounts Committee reported on the government's use of AI. Its scope was the public sector's own adoption of AI, not BridgeAI or the AI Skills Hub, and the two should not be conflated. But its findings describe the institutional environment in which the national skills programme is being run, and they are blunt.

70%	of government bodies responding to the National Audit Office's survey identified difficulties recruiting and retaining staff with AI skills as a barrier to AI adoption.
~50%	of roles advertised in civil service digital and data recruitment campaigns were unfilled in 2024.
21 of 72	highest-risk legacy digital systems, prioritised under the 2022–2025 digital and data roadmap, still lacked remediation funding.

Most striking is what the responsible department told the Committee about itself. DSIT said it had to be self-critical about digital leadership across government, observing that digital leaders are not well represented at executive level across the public sector, and that many public sector leaders do not have enough technical expertise or training.

> *"We remain sceptical that these reforms will address the issue where previous attempts have failed."*
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> — Public Accounts Committee, Use of AI in Government, HC 356, March 2025

The Committee also found there is no systematic mechanism for gathering and sharing what is learned from AI pilot activity across government, warning that without it, effort and cost would be duplicated across siloed pilots.

> **WARNING**
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> **The same failure, diagnosed twice**
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> Parliament found that government cannot systematically capture the learning from its own AI pilots. In the same period, BridgeAI's own report concluded that barriers still exist in translating pilots into production for the businesses it supports. An institution that has not solved a problem internally is attempting to solve the same problem on a national scale. That parallel is this report's own reading, not a claim either source makes.

5. Who supplies the evidence

PwC was commissioned, following what Innovate UK describes as a robust competitive tender, to design, build and run the AI Skills Hub. PwC is also named as a delivery partner of the programme.

Separately, the white paper's methodological annex states that its quantitative benchmarking was mainly drawn from large-scale datasets including the PwC Global CEO Survey, the AI Jobs Barometer and the Global Hopes and Fears Survey. PwC surveys are cited three times in the paper's own argument for the scale of the skills gap.

So one commercial firm built the platform, helps deliver the programme, and is a principal supplier of the evidence used to argue that the platform is needed. Competitive tendering is the normal route for public procurement, and nothing here suggests the process was improper. The issue is evidential independence, not procurement propriety: the skills-gap case in this document is not independent of the arrangements it justifies.

The same pattern appears at the top of the funnel. The £400 billion economic figure traces to consultancy research commissioned by a technology vendor. Neither observation requires assuming anyone acted in bad faith. Both mean the evidence base is more concentrated in interested parties than its presentation suggests.

No response from Innovate UK, PwC or DSIT to this observation has been sought at the time of writing. That is a gap in this report, and it should be closed before these findings are treated as settled — see §8.

6. What the evidence says would work

The government's own PRIMES framework, published in June 2026 under the same research programme, sets out six principles for effective AI training. Each row below adds one concrete requirement from its criteria document.

Practical	Links to real tasks; recognises existing informal AI use rather than assuming a zero starting point; states when AI should and should not be used.

Reachable	Accessible in time, format and language; designed around intersecting barriers of income, age, disability and gender, not a single average learner.
Integrated	Fits existing systems and standards; mandatory before staff use AI on regulated, confidential or safety-critical work.
Modular	Short, stackable units of 30–90 minutes, with entry at different levels and clear return points.
Expandable	Builds transferable skills across tools and roles rather than single-vendor competence.
Sustainable	Reviewed on a set cadence, with 3- and 6-month revisits; tracks confidence and quality of judgement, not just enrolment.

Two further points come from outside that programme. Sequencing research describes shifting responsibility progressively from instructor to learner, through modelling, then guided practice, then independent practice. And evidence on AI literacy training suggests it can improve how well people calibrate their own confidence, which matters because surface familiarity with AI can increase misplaced trust rather than reduce it.

There is also a working counter-example. Elements of AI, from MinnaLearn and the University of Helsinki, is vendor-neutral, requires no technical prerequisite, and is structured as six short chapters combining theory, exercises and self-reflection. It has reportedly reached around one million learners, and the LSE reviewers name it as the model the UK platform should have followed. That demonstrates reach at scale; it is not, on its own, evidence of measured learning outcomes.

7. Where this project fits

Grounded AI Practice is an independent research project, not a competitor to a national platform, and it is careful about the difference. Its working decisions to date:

Initial audience	Individuals seeking practical everyday AI literacy, with particular attention to employees at small organisations who lack the employer-provided L&D infrastructure that both PRIMES and the AI Skills Hub assume.
First output	A single pilot learning unit — not a roadmap, course library or platform — sized to PRIMES' modular criterion and sequenced accordingly, tested with real learners before anything wider is built.
Pilot capability	Effective prompting, chosen to show a learner the gap between what they type and what the model actually does with it, while teaching an immediately usable skill.

The scale difference is the point, not an apology for it. A national platform with a 10-million-worker target cannot easily run a small, well-sequenced pilot and learn from it. An independent project can, and the evidence above suggests that is exactly the step that was skipped.

8. Method, limitations and declared interests

Findings here draw on primary sources read directly wherever possible. Both Innovate UK documents and the Public Accounts Committee report were downloaded and read in full. Every source is tagged by its likely interest so that concentration in the evidence base is visible rather than hidden. Where a finding would materially affect this project's direction, confirming and disconfirming evidence was sought together.

Specific limitations, stated directly:

- No response has been sought from Innovate UK, PwC, Digital Catapult or DSIT. The observations in §5 are one-sided until that is done.
- All BridgeAI delivery figures are self-reported by a delivery partner writing for its funder. No independent audit or evaluation of BridgeAI or the AI Skills Hub has been located.
- The Public Accounts Committee report concerns government's internal use of AI, not the BridgeAI programme. It is used here as evidence about institutional capability, not about the Hub's delivery.
- No first-hand assessment of the Hub platform has been made. Unauthenticated access was refused across two research passes.
- The £400 billion figure's underlying model has not been independently reviewed, only its stated provenance and method traced.
- One frequently cited statistic — that only 18% of workers felt AI skill levels were adequate — originates from a 2021 source and is reproduced in 2026 documents without a freshness caveat. It is not relied on here.

Declared interests

This report is published by a project that proposes an alternative approach to the one it criticises. That is a real interest and is declared plainly: the author benefits if this critique is found persuasive. Readers should weigh the evidence accordingly, which is why the argument is built as far as possible from government-published material that can be checked independently.

The project has received no funding, sponsorship or support from any organisation named in this report, and holds no commercial relationship with any of them.

Sources

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Full source list, interest tagging and entry-by-entry findings are maintained in the Grounded AI Practice project repository.